EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Can One Misvah Be Enough? Why the Wicked Prosper

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 5:3-4

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 5 (Merits and Demerits), the second half of Chapter 3 and Chapter 4 (categories 3 to 5)

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 27 January 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: Two and a Half Chapters of Theodicy

Saadia likes to look at **the majority of a person's actions**. With a majority of mitzvot, a person is termed one of *zechuyot*, merits; with a majority of sins, of *chovot*, demerits. Hashem remembers everything, and every action leaves its impression on the soul.

In Chapter 2 Saadia introduced the **ten categories** of people, of which the class has seen two, the **tzaddik** and the **rasha**, and began his theodicy. The tzaddik's portion in the world to come is commensurate with his deeds, and the consequences of his minority of sins come in this world; the rasha is rewarded here for his minority of good deeds and receives the main consequences in the next. The class also discussed regret for sins and for mitzvot.

Chapter 3 so far gave the reasons **the righteous suffer**: payment for the minority of sins; a **test** for those who can bear it; and, as with young children, to **increase reward**, which the Rambam does not accept.

Tonight: why **the wicked prosper**, and then Chapter 4, the next categories of people.

Chapter 3: Six Reasons the Wicked Prosper

(The text on screen said seven; "that's a mistake, it's for six reasons.")

1. Payment for the minority

As explained in Chapter 2, the rasha receives in this world the reward for his minority of good deeds, so that his retribution in the next world is complete.

2. Hashem knows he will repent

Hashem lengthens his time in this world so that he can do teshuvah. The example is **Menashe**. Saadia does not quote it, but this is exactly the Gemara in Sanhedrin: whoever says Menashe

has no portion in the world to come weakens the hands of penitents. Menashe began to reign at twelve and reigned fifty-five years, and he did evil "like Achav." Achav reigned twenty-two years, so Menashe reigned wickedly for twenty-two years, with the idols and everything we know about him, and repented for the remaining thirty-three, "even though the teshuvah wasn't complete."

3. A righteous descendant will come from him

You yourself may not deserve to live, but your descendants are worthy. **Achaz** was a wicked king who passed his son through the fire to Molech, yet Hashem lengthened his days so that **Chizkiyahu** would come from him. **Amon** reigned two years and worshipped idols publicly, but his son was the great king **Yoshiyahu**. "You never know why a wicked person still has everything going well for him. Perhaps it's for someone. It could be a son, a grandson, it could be even a few generations down. Who knows?"

4. He is Hashem's rod

A wicked person or nation may be kept alive and prosperous to act as **the rod of Hashem's retribution**. Of Ashur, **בגוי חנף אשלחנו ועל עם עברתי אצונו**, "I send him against an ungodly nation, and against the people of My wrath I command him": Ashur, the rod of My anger, punishes Israel. "Which is difficult."

5. A righteous person asked for him

Sometimes no good will come from you, you are no emissary, and you will not repent, but a righteous person benefits from you and asks for you to be spared. When Lot fled Sedom he asked that the city of **Tzoar**, where he was staying, not be destroyed, and Hashem agreed, though the city did not deserve it in its own right. (Remember that "righteous," in Saadia's definition, means fifty-one over forty-nine, "if we're looking at it in purely mathematical terms. Obviously it's much more than that.")

6. To intensify his punishment

Hashem may keep a wicked person alive in order to intensify his final punishment. **Pharaoh** was preserved through the ten plagues for the dramatic finale: **וינער ה' את מצרים בתוך הים**, "Hashem shook off Egypt into the sea."

Yirmiyahu's question

מדוע דרך רשעים צלחה, "why does the way of the wicked prosper?" Some read it as Yirmiyahu's general question. Saadia: no, he knew the reasons; **he wanted to know which of the six was the main one**. "Fascinatingly," he was told it was the last: to give them a more intensified punishment. The Rabbi could explain this only two ways: either like Pharaoh, a more severe end, or by giving them goodness in this world so that their punishment in the next world is complete and they do not enjoy the reward of their good deeds there.

One Sin and the Fly in the Ointment

Having explained the theodicy, Saadia adds one thing. Kohelet says **זבובי מות יבאיש יביע שמן רוקח**, dead flies spoil the perfumer's precious oil, and **וחוטא אחד יאבד טובה הרבה**, "one sinner

destroys much good." How can one sin have such a terrible effect?

Saadia: it is a matter of **naming**. A person with 200 deeds, 100 merits and 100 demerits, is equally balanced, a *beinoni* (to be discussed later). One more action then changes **the definition of what kind of person he is**. Saadia does not quote it, but he clearly refers to the Gemara in **Kiddushin**: a person should always see himself as half guilty and half meritorious; one good deed makes him a tzaddik, one bad deed makes him a rasha. One sin does not change his actual deeds. He still has his 100 good deeds. But how we describe him changes, and "in that sense it can have terrible consequences."

The **Ibn Ezra** brings others who explain it differently: one sin of a person **in a position of power and influence** can do terrible damage because of its effect on the people he influences.

A Discussion: Is the Line Between Tzaddik and Rasha Fair?

"Something I really struggle with." The Rabbi put it crudely, acknowledging that no human could make these calculations with all the variables involved:

	Merits	Demerits	Category	Consequence
Person A	50.1%	49.9%	Tzaddik	A portion in the world to come; suffering here, perhaps twelve months of Gehinnom, but limited
Person B	49.9%	50.1%	Rasha	His good deeds repaid in this world; punishment in the next, "whatever punishment is," seemingly for eternity

"The difference between these two people is minuscule... How is that fair? I personally find that very difficult. I don't have an answer."

Voices from the class

- **"Who's counting?"** The Rabbi: for Hashem it is no calculation; "it's an automatic spreadsheet, if you like." ("He's got AI." "He's got more than AI, but that's not for now.")
- **The Rambam in Hilchot Teshuvah:** a participant recalled that the Rambam has a person see the whole world as balanced, so that each action can tip it. The Rabbi: when the class learnt that, they talked about **identity**. "If we take that approach then I'm happy, it makes a lot of sense, because we look at the totality of who you are," not 50.1 against 49.9. "I just feel that's the only way we can interpret Saadia."
- **Robert** asked whether all mitzvot and sins carry equal weight. "Absolutely not." He added that a tzaddik is judged by a hair's breadth, so the majority is beyond our conception. "A hundred percent. It's absolutely impossible for even the greatest human, the greatest computer, the greatest AI."
- **Lifespan:** a participant asked whether it matters how long a person lives. Everything is taken into account, "millions, perhaps billions of variables." For the Rabbi this is one of the best and simplest answers to *tzaddik vera lo*: "you've got no idea how HaKadosh Baruch Hu judges... you have no idea who's a tzaddik and who's a rasha." Some cases everyone agrees on: "I think we can all agree that Hitler was a rasha."

- **Is it judged only at the end of life?** A participant pointed out that someone near the middle could flip from day to day. "That's a very good point." The ultimate judgment is at the end of life, the great Day of Judgment, but a person is also judged every year and, as the Gemara says, **every day**. That is how Saadia explained last week why someone who improves his ways may suddenly suffer: he tipped from 49 to 51 and now his 49 must be paid here. And it can fluctuate back.
- **A tzaddik who is nearly half rasha:** a participant noted that we usually imagine a tzaddik as complete, yet Saadia's tzaddik could be doing a great deal wrong. "Most definitely." Saadia has another category for that, the **shalem**. "Tzaddik didn't mean someone who's perfect. Tzaddik means good people, generally good people," and the Rabbi believes this is how the Talmud uses the term too.
- **Doron:** in the natural world, minuscule percentages are everything. A bridge a fraction off falls down; owning one extra percent of a company gives controlling interest. If a line must be drawn somewhere, the last act tips the totality before it. "That's an excellent point." The Rabbi said his difficulty might be "more emotional than intellectual… we're talking about eternity here." Like *karet*, there must be a cut-off point where very similar people end up in very different places.
- **Rabbi David Gottlieb:** a participant recalled an essay of his, twenty or thirty years ago, giving eight answers to why the righteous suffer, among them that Hashem judges the tzaddik on a much higher scale ("he might get eight out of ten"), so his percentage goes down, while "little Johnny" who reached four when he should have reached two is credited; and **common destiny**, that we are all tied together. The Rabbi agreed: someone can be a real tzaddik inwardly and outwardly, yet the effort he puts in may not match the effort of someone we perceive as a rasha. All of this is taken into account.

Chapter 4: The Oved, One Who Serves

Saadia now returns to the ten categories.

The *oved* is a person who commits himself to a particular mitzvah and never goes against it for the rest of his life.

He may not do many other mitzvot. But this one: "I'm never going to miss tefillah at the right time… never going to do something financially improper… never going to have a forbidden relationship." One mitzvah, taken on fully, genuinely, wholeheartedly and sincerely for life. In that sense even **Esav** could be called an *oved*, for his incredible *kibbud av*. A person who has never fully committed to any single mitzvah cannot be called an *oved*.

Saadia quotes the Mishnah, **כל העושה מצוה אחת מטיבין לו**, "whoever does one mitzvah, good is done for him," and says the **Talmud Yerushalmi** explains it as one mitzvah a person chooses and keeps forever. The **Bavli** interprets the same Mishnah as referring to someone exactly balanced, fifty-fifty. The Rabbi thought Saadia accepts both: he used the Bavli's idea earlier in speaking of the majority, and now uses the Yerushalmi's for the *oved*.

The Sefer Halkkarim: one mitzvah or all of them?

"I want to stop for a moment and focus on the book Sefer Halkkarim." **Rabbi Yosef Albo** (Spain, fourteenth to fifteenth century) wrote on the principles of faith, and he quotes the

Rambam on this very point. The Rabbi read it in English:

The question: does the Torah bring a person to perfection only if he keeps all of it, or also if he keeps part?

Horn of the dilemma	Problem
All the mitzvot are needed	Then no one could reach perfection: **כי אדם אין צדיק בארץ אשר יעשה טוב ולא יחטא**. The Torah, given as an act of grace to bring Israel eternal life, would prevent them from reaching it, "and all Israel would go down to the pit."
One mitzvah is enough	Then why burden us with so many? If one simple drug cures a disease, it is idle to compound many. "It's vain to accomplish with many acts what can be realised with one."

Albo's answer: many things in nature are not strictly necessary but amplify. One eye would be enough to see, but two let us see at all angles and in depth. So Hashem multiplied the ways to perfection, not all of them necessary, but making it easier to reach. This is the meaning of the Mishnah **רצה הקב"ה לזכות את ישראל לפיכך הרבה להם תורה ומצות**: Hashem wanted to give Israel merit, so He gave them many mitzvot, more opportunities.

And so, Albo writes, **the Rambam** says in his Commentary on the Mishnah that it is one of the principles of faith that **if a person does one of the 613 mitzvot properly and correctly, without mixing in any other intention or self-interest, he merits a portion in the world to come**.

"Like you say, if you want to do well in business, diversify." The more mitzvot, the more chances. Albo adds that of course the more one does, the greater one's portion. But one mitzvah, done properly, sincerely, wholeheartedly, for no reason but the service of HaKadosh Baruch Hu, makes a person an *oved* with a portion in the world to come.

"That's something we can all think about. What is it that we can turn back to at the end of our lives, on our deathbeds, and say: this is something I was completely committed to for my entire life, and I never veered from it."

What counts as "for its own sake"?

A participant asked whether enjoying the mitzvah counts as an ulterior motive. The Rabbi: "The Rambam clearly says doing a mitzvah for reward does not work." It means doing it because I love God and want to be close to Him. "When you love someone, you really, really love them... I just want to do everything you've told me to do because I want to make you pleased and happy." That is *lishmah*. "Of course such a level is very difficult," but the more one tries, the likelier it becomes, like the golfer who said: **"the harder I practise, the luckier I get."** Hopefully one action in our lives will be done for no other reason than that it is Hashem's mitzvah.

A participant told a story of the **Vilna Gaon** explaining to his study partner that he had gone over everything a hundred times. **Flora** connected it to the Gemara on **ושבתם וראיתם... בין עבד אלהים לאשר לא עבדו**: the difference between one who served and one who did not is between someone who revised his learning a hundred times and someone who revised it a hundred

and one times. The Rabbi's suggestion: a hundred times you may be doing for yourself, to remember it; the hundred and first is because this is the Torah of Hashem and you love it. "It's not the difference of the one."

Category 4: The Mamre, the Disobedient

The *mamre* is someone with **one mitzvah he rejects**. Some mitzvot he works hard at, believes in and finds sensible; one he does not care about. Saadia cites the saying that **every person has his own law**, according to the variety of human beings. The Rabbi gave "a much later saying": everyone thinks they are in the centre. Anyone more religious is to the right; anyone less religious is not religious enough. We all have things we are more and less particular about. That is fine. The problem is **rejecting** something: "I'm not doing that."

The Hebrew term is **מומר לדבר אחד**, someone rebellious regarding one thing. The text on screen had a mistake here, the Rabbi noted.

The halachic consequence: conversion

This has consequences in halachah. The Rabbi brought a classic teshuvah of the **Achiezer**, Rabbi Chaim Ozer Grodzinski, from over a hundred years ago. A convert must accept the entire Torah; one who rejects a single thing is not converted. Yet many women who convert today will not be covering their hair, which is a mitzvah, whether from the Torah or the Chachamim. How can batei din convert them?

The Achiezer's answer is exactly this distinction, between **קבלת מצות**, accepting the mitzvot, and **עשיית מצות**, doing them.

- "How many of us have so many things we want to do in life, we aspire to do, but we haven't done yet? Whether it's going to the gym, eating more healthily, spending more time with our spouses." There are many mitzvot we should be doing and do not. "It's a problem, but fine. One day, hopefully, you'll do it." Such a convert can be accepted.
- The problem is someone who says: this mitzvah I reject; it is sexist, it is patriarchal. Rejection out of conviction is the *mamre*: "even if it's one mitzvah, that's a problem."

Category 5: The Shalem, the Complete

The *shalem* is the completely righteous person **who does everything correctly**. (This answers the earlier point: the ordinary tzaddik is the majority; the *shalem* is the one we nowadays call a tzaddik.)

Some people think no human can keep every mitzvah. Saadia: **it is possible**. Otherwise Hashem would not have commanded the mitzvot. And the atonements in the Torah? They are written **for the potential**: if you sin, here is the way back. That does not mean you must sin.

And the verse **כי אדם אין צדיק בארץ אשר יעשה טוב ולא יחטא**, "there is no righteous man on earth who does good and does not sin"? Saadia reads it as: there is no one, even a tzaddik, who does good **without the possibility of sinning**. It does not say he sins; it says he could.

"Now this is a remarkable interpretation, certainly not the simple interpretation." The **Ibn Ezra** and others read it as it sounds: humans sin. And it contradicts an explicit Gemara in

Sanhedrin:

Rabbi Eliezer fell ill and his students came to visit. They wept; **Rabbi Akiva** laughed. Why are you crying? How can we not cry, when the great Rabbi Eliezer is in pain? Rabbi Akiva: that is why I laugh. When I saw everything going well for my teacher, I thought perhaps he was receiving his reward in this world. Now that I see him suffering, I am glad: his portion in the world to come is secure. Rabbi Eliezer asked: have I neglected anything of the Torah? Rabbi Akiva answered: **you yourself taught us, "there is no righteous man on earth who does good and does not sin."**

So the Gemara understands the verse simply: people do sin. (The Rabbi noted in passing that Rabbi Akiva is the symbol of hope in many Gemarot where everyone else cries and he laughs, a subject of a past shiur.) There is also the Gemara that **four people died only through the serpent's counsel**, without sin of their own, which would seem to support Saadia. "In any case, it's quite remarkable. Saadia believes it's possible for a person to be absolutely perfect and never to do something wrong."

Summary

1. **Six reasons the wicked prosper:** payment for their minority of good deeds; Hashem knows they will **repent** (Menashe); a **righteous descendant** will come from them (Achaz, Amon); they serve as **Hashem's rod** (Ashur); a **righteous person asked** for them (Tzoar); and to **intensify their punishment** (Pharaoh). Yirmiyahu was told the main reason is the last.
2. **"One sinner destroys much good"** is about **naming**: one act can change a balanced person's category, not erase his deeds. The Ibn Ezra brings the influence of the powerful.
3. **The fairness of a razor-thin line** troubled the Rabbi. The class suggested identity, unequal weights, countless variables, daily judgment, and that tipping points are part of reality. "You have no idea who's a tzaddik and who's a rasha."
4. **The *oved*:** one who commits to **one mitzvah** for life (the Yerushalmi). **Sefer HaIkkarim** and **the Rambam**: one mitzvah done perfectly *lishmah* earns the world to come; the many mitzvot are many opportunities.
5. **The *mamre*:** one who **rejects** even one mitzvah. The **Achiezer** distinguishes accepting mitzvot from doing them, with consequences for conversion.
6. **The *shalem*:** one who keeps everything. Saadia holds it is **possible**, reading Kohelet as speaking of the *capacity* to sin, against the simple reading and the Gemara of Rabbi Eliezer and Rabbi Akiva.

Coming Up

Next week, at the usual time of 6 o'clock: the rest of Chapter 4, categories six to nine (the **mekatzer**, negligent; the **choteh**, offender; the **mezid**, rebellious offender; and the **kofer**, unbeliever), and then the **penitent** and Saadia's discussion of **teshuvah**.

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